The Panel of the Defiant

A short story for the last session of Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Age

Scott and Claude

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Somebody had made three name tents out of folded card stock and set them on the folding table at the front of the BOLLI classroom. Then somebody, probably Scott, had made a fourth, and set it at the end.

UNDERGROUND MAN. WINSTON SMITH. NEO. SAI.

The fourth chair was empty.

"He's not coming?" Fran asked, settling into the second row with her coffee and the look of a woman who had expected nothing and been proven right.

"He sent regrets," Scott said. He held up his phone. "Very gracious. Perfect grammar. 'Sai is sorry to miss what will surely be a meaningful conversation and wishes everyone a restful weekend.' "

"*Sai* is sorry," Fran said. "Third person. You know who writes in the third person."

"His assistant," Marvin said darkly. He was eighty-one and had brought a legal pad, as he had to every session, and had written at the top of a fresh page, in block capitals, ASK ABOUT THE ESSAY.[1]

"Even his no was written by someone else," Fran said. "That's a hell of a way to end a course."

"We haven't ended it yet," said Arthur.

Dorothy said nothing. She was watching the door.

I.

They came in one at a time, the way old men come into a room they are not sure they belong in.

The Underground Man came first. He was small and yellowish and wore a coat too heavy for October, and he stopped just inside the doorway as though the room had insulted him. He looked at the coffee urn, the tray of Danish, the whiteboard with *SESSION 5: WHERE DO WE GO FROM HERE?* written across it

[1] Defiance to Mind Control: From the Crystal Palace to Tilly

in green marker, and the ten or so faces turned toward him. His lip curled. Then, unexpectedly, he took a Danish.

Winston Smith came second. He was taller than anyone had pictured, stooped, with the careful walk of a man whose varicose ulcer had never entirely healed. He had a habit, Dorothy noticed right away, of glancing at the projector in the ceiling, then at the smoke detector, then at the little black eye of the laptop camera on Scott's podium. Once he had found them all, he seemed to relax a little, as though the trick was not to escape being watched but to know exactly where the watching was.

Neo came last. He was the youngest of the three, if seventy-three can be called young, and his hair had gone completely white. He wore a black overcoat, of course, but it had a missing button and a library receipt sticking out of the pocket. He nodded to the room, and before he sat down, he touched the edge of the table lightly with two fingers, as if to check that it was there.

"Thank you all for coming," Scott said. "And thank you for, ah, traveling."

"I did not travel," said the Underground Man, with his mouth full. "I was *transported*. There is a difference. One is an act, and the other is something done to you. Write that down." He pointed at Marvin, who, to his own surprise, wrote it down.

II.

Scott had planned the session carefully. Each guest would speak for five minutes on the essay the class had read, "Defiance to Mind Control: From the Crystal Palace to Tilly," and on how, after thirty-odd years of living in the future, they now understood their own stories. Then questions. Then, he hoped, something like a conclusion.

The plan lasted about ninety seconds.

"I have read your essay," the Underground Man began, "and I wish to say at once that it is a very good essay, very clear, very *accessible*." He gave the word a little twist, like wringing out a rag. "You have put me in a timeline. Number two, right after the nihilists. 'His form of defiance: spite.' Spite! As if I chose it from a menu. As if I said, today I will have the spite, and a side of liver ailment."

"Isn't that what you did?" Fran asked.

He turned to her with real delight. "Yes! Of course it is! That is exactly what I did. But you are not supposed to *say* so. You are supposed to argue with me, and then I will be wounded, and I will go home and write forty pages about how you wounded me. That is how I know I exist."

"You have a lot of time on your hands," Fran said.

"I have had a hundred and sixty years on my hands, madam, and I have spent them extremely badly."

A few people laughed. He looked pleased, and then, almost immediately, ashamed of looking pleased. Dorothy found she rather liked him.

"Here is what I want to say," he went on, "and then I will be quiet, which I will not. When I was forty, I said that the planners would one day prove that man is 'something of the nature of a piano-key.'[2] I said they would tabulate all our desires 'like tables of logarithms.' I said it to be outrageous. I said it in a cellar, to nobody. And then I was brought here, and I discovered that you have done it. You have actually done it. Every morning a little glass rectangle tells me what I will want for breakfast, and it is *correct*. Do you know what that does to a man like me? It is like spending your whole life shouting that the house is on fire, and then the fire department arrives, and they are very polite, and they bring you a blanket."

"So you were right," Arthur said.

"Being right is the worst thing that ever happened to me."

[2] Fyodor Dostoevsky, *Notes from Underground* (1864), trans. Constance Garnett, Part I, ch. 7, where the Underground Man also imagines our actions "tabulated" like "tables of logarithms." See also "Defiance to Mind Control: From the Crystal Palace to Tilly, section 2."

III.

Winston spoke more quietly. He had a notebook in front of him, an ordinary spiral one from CVS, and he did not open it.

"When they brought me here, I was," he paused, choosing a word, "finished. You've all read the end of the book. I don't need to tell you what I felt about Big Brother by then." He turned his gin-stained voice toward the window. "For the first ten years, I couldn't sit in a room without a telescreen. I'd turn on the television just to have something looking at me. My first landlady, in Somerville, thought I was lonely. I wasn't lonely. I was afraid of being unobserved. I didn't know who I would be if no one was checking."

The room had gone very still.

"It came back slowly. The thing they took. It came back the way feeling comes back into a frozen hand, which is to say it hurt. I read the essay you gave us, and I want to say the bit about two and two is right. The Underground Man wanted the right to say five. I wanted the right to say four. We look like opposites, and we aren't. We both wanted a mind that answers to itself."

"Thank you," said the Underground Man, surprised.

"I'm not finished," Winston said, without heat. "What the essay doesn't say, because how could it, is that I *did* say five, in the end. I said it and meant it. So when I came here, I couldn't trust four, either. I couldn't trust anything I believed, because I knew I could be made to believe the opposite with enough pain. Do you understand? It wasn't that they lied to me. It's that they proved belief could be manufactured. After that you don't get your innocence back. You only get," he lifted one hand, "vigilance."

Marvin cleared his throat. "That's how I feel about the videos," he said. "My grandson sends me a video of a senator. I can't tell if it's real. It isn't that I believe the fake. It's that I can't believe the real one, either."

Winston looked at him for a long moment. "Yes," he said. "That's exactly it. They don't need you to believe the lie anymore. They just need you to stop being sure of anything. It's cheaper."

IV.

Neo had been listening with his hands folded on the table, very still, in a way that made Scott think of a cat watching a bird feeder.

"I'll be honest," Neo said. "I read your essay twice, and the part I keep going back to is the part about Baudrillard."

"Oh dear," Scott said.

"No, it's fair. He said our movie was the kind of film about the matrix the matrix itself would have made. I was angry about that for years. I thought, what does he know, he wasn't *there*, he didn't see the fields, the pods, the rust. I saw the desert of the real. I stood in it."

He turned his hands over and looked at them, the same gesture the class had read about in "DMC Protagonists React to the Manifesto," the one where he paces the ship and asks Trinity whether love is just another program.[3] Several people noticed and exchanged glances.

"But here's the thing I figured out, about thirty years in," Neo went on. "He wasn't saying the desert wasn't real. He was saying the *story* was too clean. Red pill, blue pill. Inside, outside. Asleep, awake. One chosen guy who wakes up and saves everyone. That story is a product, too. It sells really well. It sells to every kid who thinks he's the only one who sees through it." He smiled faintly. "I was that kid. A lot of people online are that kid now. Everybody's taken the red pill. Everybody's the only one awake. And they're all awake in exactly the same way, and somebody's making money on it."

"So there's no outside," Marvin said.

[3]From the optional course reading "DMC Protagonists React to Manifesto," which includes Julian's "Manifesto for the Hearth in the Storm" and the reactions of the Underground Man, Winston, Neo and Sai. The Underground Man's threat to smash Julian's teacups, Winston at the memory hole, and Neo's questions to Trinity all come from that piece.

"There's an outside. I've been there. It's cold and the food is terrible." Neo laughed. "But I don't think the outside is a place anymore. I think it's—" he stopped, and for a moment the old blankness came over his face, the look of a man waiting for something to be downloaded into him. Nothing came. "I don't know what it is. I used to know kung fu in a second. Now I'm seventy-three and I have to figure things out the slow way, like everybody else. It's humiliating. It's also the first thing that's ever felt like mine."

V.

It was Dorothy who started the fire, although she would have denied it.

"I want to ask Mr. Smith something," she said. Winston turned toward her politely. "You talk about vigilance. And I understand, after what was done to you. But I'm seventy-seven. My phone reminds me to take my pills. When I fell last winter, it's how my daughter knew to come. I've buried a husband and a sister. Is it really so terrible to let something look after me? Isn't there a difference between a machine that watches *over* you and one that watches you?"

"No," said Winston.

"No, there isn't a difference? Or no, it isn't terrible?"

"No, there isn't a difference. There's only a difference in how it feels." He said it gently, but he said it. "O'Brien looked after me, too. He told me so. He said he'd watched me for seven years. He said he was going to cure me. He brought me water. He was the kindest man I ever knew, at the end."

Dorothy flushed. "My phone is not O'Brien."

"I didn't say it was. I said the kindness doesn't tell you anything. The kindness is the part they're best at."

"That's paranoid," Dorothy said.

"It's *experienced*," Winston said, and for the first time his voice rose. "You've had a long life, Mrs.—"

"Dorothy."

"Dorothy. You've had a long life, and I respect it. But you've had a long life in a country where most of the time, the people watching you didn't want very much from you. That's luck. It isn't a law of nature. It can change in an afternoon. I've seen it change. It doesn't announce itself. It just stops bringing the water."

Arthur, in the back, said, "That's what I keep trying to tell people about Washington—"

"Oh, here we go," said Fran.

"No, let him go," said the Underground Man, who had brightened considerably. "I love it when people bring politics into a discussion of literature. It means the literature has finally become useful, and therefore ruined."

Arthur ignored him. "I'm just saying. Everything we've read in this course, the surveillance, the rewriting of history, the people who can't tell real from fake, the comfort that makes everybody stop paying attention. It's not fiction. It's the news. And I sat in the back of this room for five weeks while we analyzed it. *Analyzed* it. Meanwhile I've written to my representatives eleven times. I've been to four protests. My knees are shot. And you know what this course has made me feel? Like the whole thing's a seminar. Like we're Julian's little group in the basement with the kettle, congratulating ourselves for *understanding*."

There was a silence.

"Well," said the Underground Man softly. "Well, well. *Now* we are getting somewhere."

VI.

He stood up. He was not tall, and his coat made him look like a heap of laundry that had decided to speak.

"I read Julian's little manifesto," he said. "The *Hearth in the Storm*. A covenant of soft expectations. And I wrote a response, or rather"—he glanced at Scott—"*someone* wrote a response, in my voice, and put my

name on it. I called him a coward. I said he wanted to be a hero without getting up from his sofa. I said I would burst into his basement and smash his teacups."

"You did say that," Marvin said, checking his notes.

"I *know* I said it. I said it *about myself*. That was the joke. That was always the joke." He swept an arm around the room: the folding tables, the Danish, the whiteboard, the eight retired people in cardigans and fleece. "Look where we are. A room with four walls. A warm urn of coffee. A few souls who refuse to let the machine do their thinking. This is Julian's basement! You are all Julian! *I* am Julian! I have been Julian for a hundred and sixty years! I just used to be very rude about it!"

"I am not Julian," Arthur said, and his ears had gone red. "I *go out*. I *do things*."

"You write to your representatives! Eleven times! Do they write back?"

"They send form letters."

"Generated by a machine!"

"Probably," Arthur admitted.

"So you write to the Crystal Palace, and the Crystal Palace writes back, very politely, thanking you for your engagement, and then it files your letter under 'constituent sentiment, mildly agitated,' and adjusts the messaging by two percent. That is your resistance! That is a Crystal Palace with a clipboard!"

"*That's enough*," Arthur said, standing up, and for a moment the two old men were glaring at each other across three rows of chairs, and Scott had the distinct and unprecedented thought, *I may have to break up a fight at BOLLI.*

"At least I'm trying," Arthur said. "At least I'm not sitting in a cellar for a century and a half, sneering at everyone who tries."

The Underground Man opened his mouth. Then he closed it. He looked, suddenly, very old.

"Yes," he said. "That is a fair point. That is the fairest point anyone has made to me since 1864." He sat down. "I hate it."

VII.

It was Winston who spoke next, and he spoke to the Underground Man, not to the room.

"You played at it," he said quietly. "Two and two make five. You said it to annoy the planners. You said it was 'sometimes a very charming thing too.'[4] I remember the line. I read it in my first year here, in the Somerville library, and I had to go outside and sit on the steps."

The Underground Man said nothing.

"It wasn't charming, when they did it to me. It was a man holding up four fingers and turning a dial. So when you stand up and tell this man"—he nodded at Arthur—"that his letters are useless, I want you to remember that you never had to find out what useless really means. You got to keep your cellar. You got to keep your spite. I'd have given anything for a cellar."

"I am sorry," the Underground Man said, and to everyone's astonishment, including apparently his own, he meant it. "I am sorry. I will regret having said that I am sorry for the rest of the week. But I am."

"And you," Winston said to Arthur, a little more gently. "He's not entirely wrong. They want you to write the letters. They have a place to put them. The question is whether there's anything you do that they *don't* have a place to put."

"Like what?" Arthur said.

[4]The Undeground Man's statement "twice two makes five is sometimes a very charming thing too" is from *Notes from Underground*, Part I, ch. 9: Winston's own counter-claim, that freedom is the freedom to say two plus two make four, is from *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, Part One, ch. 7.

Winston thought about it. “Julia,” he said finally. “When she and I were together, that was the only thing they didn’t have a form for. Not the rebellion. That was all theirs, it turned out. The Brotherhood was theirs. The book was theirs. But the afternoons in the room above the shop, that was ours, for a while. They had to go to a great deal of trouble to take that. That’s how I knew it was worth something. They don’t go to trouble over things that don’t matter.”

VIII.

Neo had not said anything for a long time. Now he looked at Dorothy.

“Can I answer your question?” he said. “The one you asked Winston?”

Dorothy nodded.

“In that essay, the one where we all react to the manifesto, they had me asking Trinity whether love was real or just more code. Whether the machines put it there so we’d keep breeding in our vats.” He gave a small smile. “That’s a pretty good guess at what I was thinking at thirty. I was always asking her to tell me what was real.”

“And?” said Dorothy.

“She died,” Neo said simply. “You know that, if you saw the sequels. Most people try not to.” A few people laughed, gently. “And here’s what I learned. The machines had a use for everything about me. My body heat. My anger. My hope; they even had a use for that, they built it into the system, the Architect told me so to my face. But they had no use at all for how much it hurt when she was gone. Nobody could farm that. Nobody could sell it. It didn’t power anything. That’s how I knew it was real.”

Dorothy’s eyes were wet. “Forty-one years,” she said. “My Howard.”

“Then you know,” Neo said. “You don’t need me to tell you. The phone that tells you to take your pills is fine. Let it. But the thing that let you know it hurt when Howard died—don’t let anybody, or anything, offer to take that off your hands. That’s the part they’d most like to smooth over. Not because they’re evil. Because it’s *inefficient*.”

Dorothy was quiet for a moment. “My phone,” she said slowly, “suggested a grief support app. About a week after the funeral. I thought it was thoughtful.”

“It probably was,” Neo said. “That’s the trouble.”

IX.

Marvin raised his hand. He had been waiting forty minutes.

“I have a question about the essay,” he said, tapping his legal pad. “Not *the* essay[5]. The other one[6]. The reactions. And the one with all of us answering questions.[7]”

Scott winced slightly. He had known this was coming.

“I read the byline,” Marvin said. “ ‘Scott Axelrod with Gemini.’ And the other one, the big essay, says ‘Scott and Claude.’ So.” He turned to the three guests. “When you read the versions of yourselves those things wrote. The Underground Man smashing teacups, Winston at the memory hole, Neo with Trinity. Was that you? Did the machine get you right?”

There was a pause.

“Yes,” said the Underground Man. “Damn it. Mostly yes.”

[5] Defiance to Mind Control: From the Crystal Palace to Tilly

[6] DMC Protagonist React to Manifesto by Scott and Gemini

[7] Responses to Questions by Story Characters and Fictional Students by Scott and Claude

"Close enough that it frightened me," said Winston. "It had my fear right. It didn't have my hands. It didn't know about the ulcer, or that I still can't drink gin, or that the smell of boiled cabbage makes me happy now, which I can't explain to anyone."

"It made me younger and more certain," said Neo. "Which is what I'd expect. It learned me from the movie."

"So here's my question," said Marvin, and he looked at Scott. "We spent five weeks on mind control. On machines that know us better than we know ourselves. And the course materials were written by a machine that knows *them* better than—" He waved at the panel. "Isn't that a problem?"

Every head turned toward Scott.

Scott, who had been a teacher long enough to know that the best moments in a class are the ones you didn't plan and can't control, took a breath.

"Yes," he said. "It's a problem. That's partly why I did it."

"To make a point?" Fran said skeptically.

"To find out where the point *was*." He came out from behind the podium. "I used the machines the way you'd use a very well-read research assistant who's never had a body. They're good at the shape of a thing. They gave me Dostoevsky's sentences and Orwell's fear and Neo's questions, and they were often right. But look what just happened. Winston told us about the cabbage. Neo told us about the grief. The Underground Man apologized, which, if I'd asked a machine to predict, it would have said was out of character."

"It *was* out of character," the Underground Man said. "I am furious about it."

"And Dorothy told us about the grief app," Scott said. "And Arthur stood up. None of that was in the materials. None of it could have been. That's the part that's left over. That's what Deleuze was getting at in the handout. The question at the bottom."

Marvin found it in his folder and read it aloud: " 'How would you know if you were being controlled by something that never once told you no?' "[8]

"So how *would* you know?" Arthur asked. He had sat back down.

Scott shook his head. "I don't think you can know it in your head. I think you find out the way Winston found out about Julia, or Neo found out about Trinity. You notice the thing in your life they'd most like to smooth over. The friction. The inefficiency. The argument in a room like this one that doesn't lead to a product. And you protect that. Not because it wins. Because it's yours."

"That sounds like Julian's manifesto," Fran said. "Sit in a room, understand the storm, feel noble."

"It would be," Scott admitted, "if we stayed in the room."

X.

It was Fran, of all people, who ended it.

"Can I say the exhausted thing?" she said. "Somebody has to." She set down her coffee. "I'm seventy-four. I was a hospital administrator for thirty years. I watched every new system come in promising to save us time, and every one of them took more time, and then we couldn't remember how we'd done it without them. So I don't believe in resistance, really. I don't believe in the red pill or the Brotherhood or writing to Congress. I think whatever's coming is coming."

"Then why did you take the course?" asked the Underground Man, genuinely curious.

Fran considered. "Because I wanted to sit in a room with people who'd argue with me," she said. "Out loud. Badly. Where I could see their faces. My whole life is people agreeing with me now. My feed agrees with me. My doctor's portal agrees with me. My granddaughter agrees with me because she wants to get off the

[8]The closing question of the optional readings Two Kinds Of Control, which relates Michel Foucault's "Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison" to Gilles Deleuze's Postcript on the Societies of Control (1990).

phone." She shrugged. "You," she said to the Underground Man, "are the first person in two years who's told me I'm wrong to my face. I don't know if it's resistance. But I'll take it."

The Underground Man looked at her as though no one had ever said anything kind to him in his life, which was nearly true.

"Madam," he said, "you are wrong about almost everything."

"Thank you," said Fran.

XI.

Afterward, the guests lingered by the coffee urn, which none of them had expected to do.

Winston stood at the whiteboard. Someone had erased *WHERE DO WE GO FROM HERE?*, and he picked up the green marker and wrote, in careful, slightly shaky letters:

2 + 2 = 4

He looked at it for a while. Then the Underground Man came up beside him, took the marker out of his hand, and underneath, in a cramped, violent scrawl, wrote:

(sometimes 5)

Winston looked at it. He didn't laugh, exactly. But something in his face loosened, and he took the marker back and drew a little box around both lines together, as if to say: *Both. Keep both. That's the room they can't get into.*

Neo was talking to Dorothy by the window. Arthur had cornered Marvin about a town meeting in Newton next month. Fran was explaining hospital billing software to the Underground Man, who was listening with the rapt horror of a man watching his worst prophecies acted out in triplicate.

Scott's phone buzzed.

It was a text from a number he didn't recognize. No capitals, two typos, no assistant's polish.

> *sory. it said i shoudn't come. said youd understand. i didnt let it decide this time. took the train, then walked. got lost twice. im outside. is it too late*

Scott looked out the window. On the path below, a young man in very good shoes was standing in the drizzle, looking up at the building, with no idea which door was the right one.

Scott looked at the empty chair at the end of the table, and the name tent that said SAI.

It was the last session. There was no next week.

Maybe, Scott thought, *there should be.*

He went down to open the door.

Footnotes